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EVALUATE · TRAIN · BUILD

The **Art** of Hiring

- Evaluating candidates [30 MIN]
- Training interviewers [30 MIN]
- Building the process [30 MIN]

Philosophy, content and process borrowed heavily from TellApart, Twitter, Wade Chambers, and "Who: The A Method for Hiring". Three arcs, about 30 minutes each.

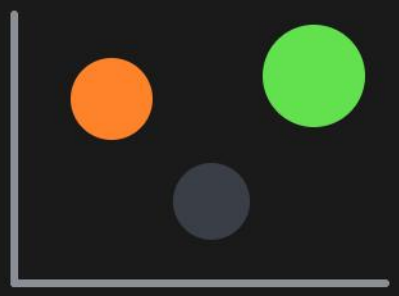
[THE WHOLE TALK]

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Every company interviews.
Few train their interviewers.

01 · EVALUATE

Strength × Fit



Who should we hire?

02 · TRAIN

Five levels



What makes an interviewer great?

03 · BUILD

3-stage process



How do we run it?

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The whole talk on one slide. Arc 1: how we evaluate candidates, on two axes: Strength and Fit. Arc 2: how we train interviewers, through five levels from Competence to Landing. Arc 3: how we build the process, in three stages: getting to the interview, the interview, the close.
Philosophy, content and process borrowed heavily from TellApart, Twitter, Wade Chambers, and "Who: The A Method for Hiring".

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[ARC 2 · TRAINING INTERVIEWERS]

Your job: build the hiring machine.

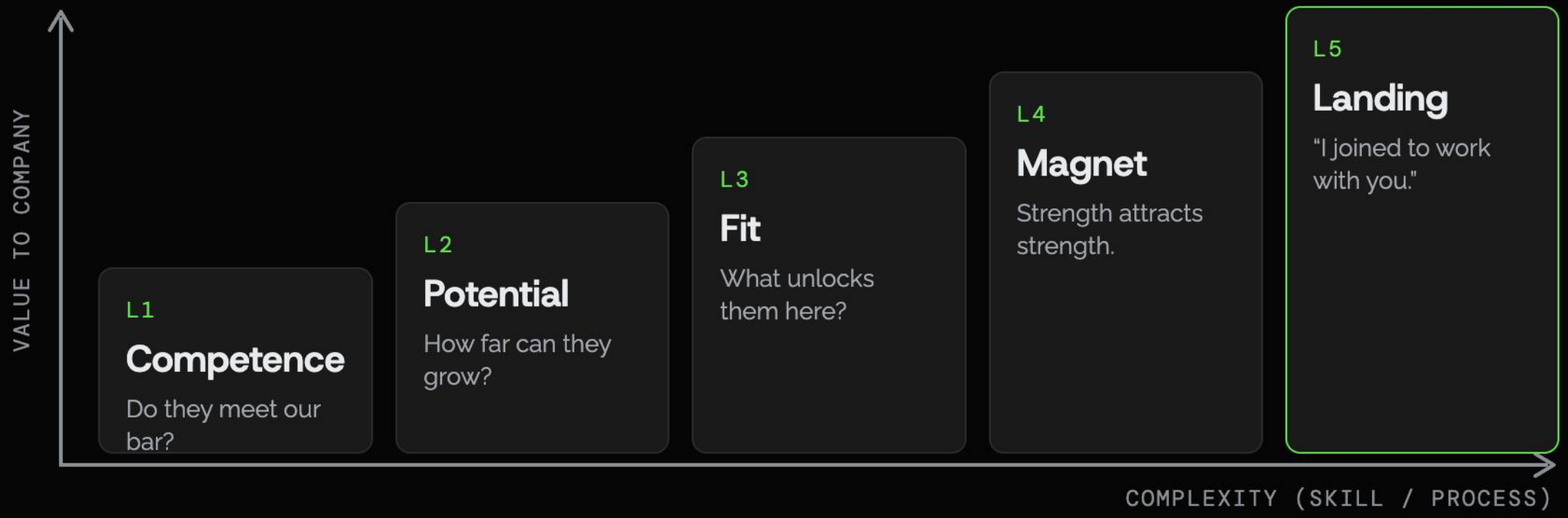
As an EM, that means training your interviewers.

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Your job as an Engineering Manager is to BUILD the hiring process, which requires training your interviewers. Arc 1 was who to hire. Arc 2 is how each interviewer gets great at finding and landing them.

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Five levels of an A-player interviewer.



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The five levels: Competence, Potential, Fit, Magnet, Landing. Each one is more complex to master (skill and process) and more valuable to the company. Most interviewers live at L1. The goal is an interviewer who works all five.

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How the levels work.

01
Builds on the last
Higher levels build on lower ones.

02
Start anywhere
You don't need to master a level before working on the next.

03
Harder each step
Difficulty of mastery rises with each level.

04
Taught on its own
Each level is trained independently.

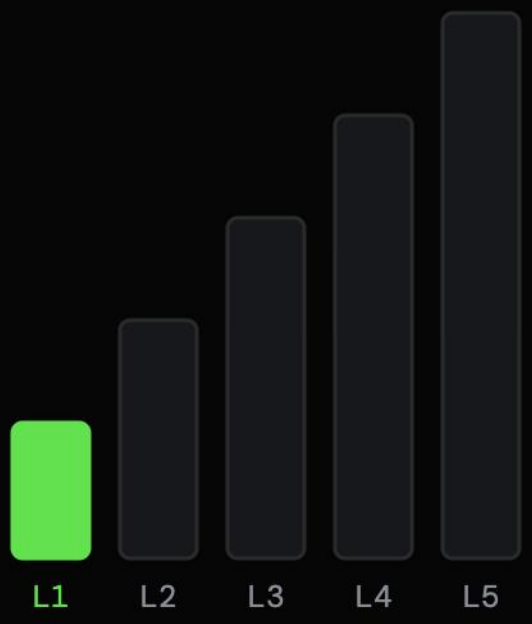
05
Overlays the loop
Every stage of the interview process uses them.

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Higher levels build on lower levels. Mastery of a lower level is not required to start working on higher levels. Difficulty in mastery increases with level. Each level is taught independently. And the levels overlay the interview process: every stage uses them.

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Do they meet our technical bar?



Applied intelligence + technical competence.

GOOD	Finds valuable strengths using standard questions or problems.
BETTER	Changes style to fit the candidate: standard questions, interactive problem solving, or their past work.
BEST	Makes it look easy.

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L1, Competence. Question: do they meet our technical bar? Two things: applied intelligence and technical competence. Good: able to find valuable strength(s) using standard questions/problems. Better: able to change styles based on the candidate (standard questions vs. interactive problem solving vs. interviewing using their past). Best: make it look easy. It gets much harder to evaluate at higher levels of seniority.

[L1 · COMPETENCE]

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Senior isn't "knows what I know."

WRONG BAR

"Do they know what I know?"

Knowledge comes from experience. Yours and theirs aren't comparable.

RIGHT BAR

"What should they know, given their path?"

Read the résumé, then test what that experience should have taught them.

LOOK FOR Judgment Good questions Improvisation

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How do you determine senior level? It is not "do they know what I know": knowledge is based on experience, so it is not directly comparable. You need to understand what they SHOULD know based on their résumé and experience. Look for judgment, good questions, improvisation. [Clip from The Matrix: TBD.]

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[CASE STUDY]

Sanjay

[Co-Founder, Abnormal]

Goes deep, respectfully.

THE MOVE

Takes them to the ground in their own expertise.

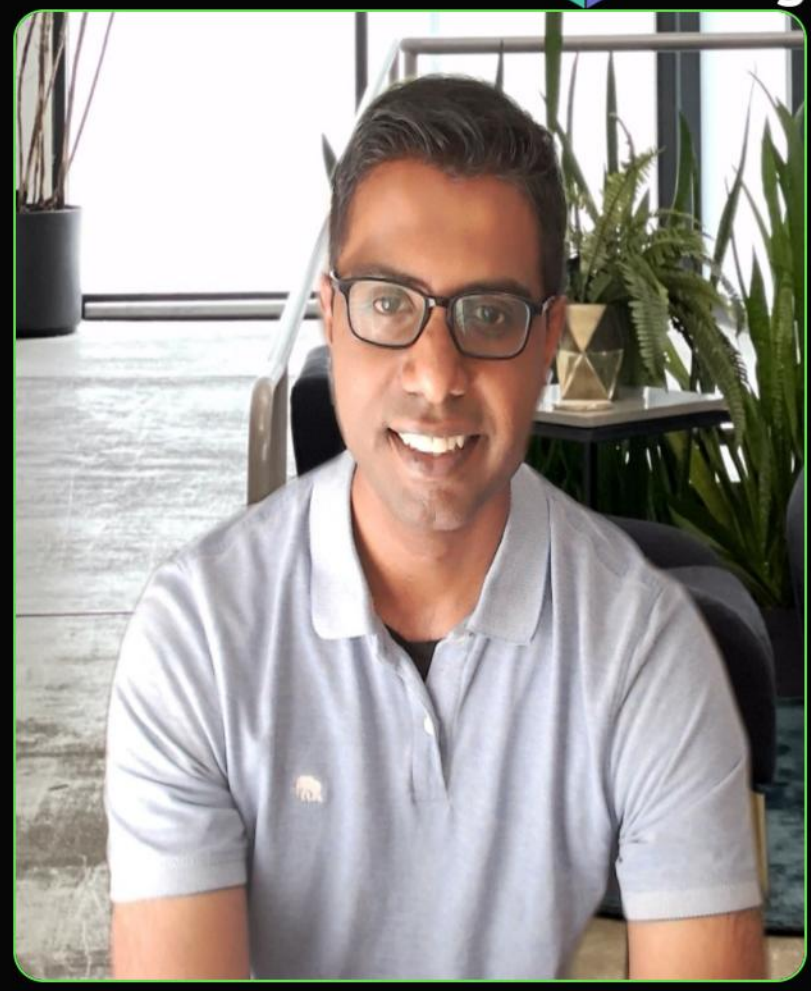
THE INVITE

"Interview me. See how well I know this."

STEAL THIS

Depth they respect, without threat.

(Strength attracts strength.)



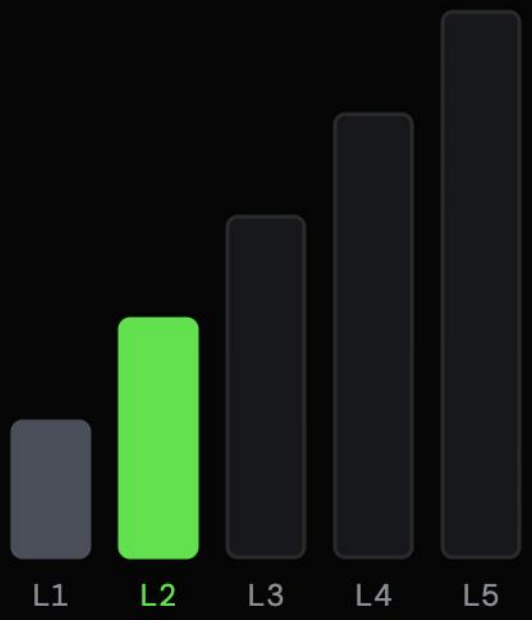
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Sanjay. Takes the candidate down to the ground in their area of expertise, respectfully. Also: interview me, and see how well I know this area.

[L2 · POTENTIAL]

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What is their potential?



Interviewing for potential, not just today's skill.

GOOD	Finds repeated examples of high-potential behavior.
BETTER	Finds the limits: what are their blind spots?
BEST	Knows whether what unlocks their potential exists here.

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L2, Potential. Good: able to find repeated examples of high-potential behaviors (motivation, curiosity, insight, engagement, determination). Better: able to determine limitations in those behaviors: what are their blind spots? Best: able to correctly determine whether the things necessary to unlock their potential exist here. That last one is the bridge to L3.

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What does potential look like?

01
Motivation
A fierce commitment to excel in pursuit of unselfish goals.

02
Curiosity
Seeks new experiences, knowledge and candid feedback, to grow.

03
Insight
Gathers and makes sense of information that suggests new possibilities.

04
Engagement
Uses emotion and logic to communicate a persuasive vision and connect.

05
True Grit
Fights for difficult goals and bounces back from adversity.

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Five high-potential traits. Motivation: a fierce commitment to excel in the pursuit of unselfish goals. Curiosity: seeks new experiences, knowledge, and candid feedback, with a focus on growing. Insight: the ability to gather and make sense of information that suggests new possibilities. Engagement: a knack for using emotion and logic to communicate a persuasive vision and connect with people. Determination: the wherewithal to fight for difficult goals despite challenges, and to bounce back from adversity. (These five come from Claudio Fernández-Aráoz, "21st-Century Talent Spotting", HBR 2014.)

[L2 · POTENTIAL]

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How do you test potential in a technical interview?

Ask the room. Capture answers live.

?

?

?

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Open question to the room: how do you test for potential inside a technical interview? Capture answers live, on the slide or a whiteboard.

[CASE STUDY]

Steven

[Sr. Engineer, Mashgin]

Imagines them **already on his team.**

THE MOVE

Keep interview questions **open ended --** see where they go.

THE TELL

When the candidate expresses original thought & judgement

STEAL THIS

Show them we value curiousity and creativity.

("I'm incredibly biased toward raw talent")

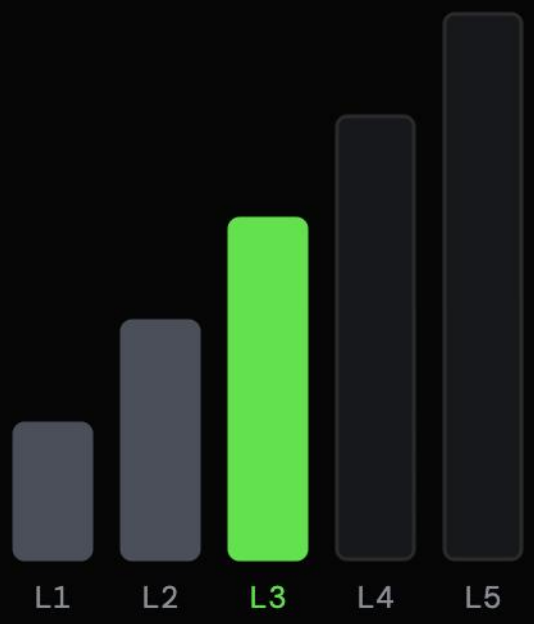


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Steven. “They would be great on my team,” and the candidate feels it.

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What unlocks their potential HERE?



A mix of alignment, role requirements and cultural fit.

GOOD	Understands their goals, the environment they need and any culture issues, and believes all three work here.
BETTER	Can lay out a plan (projects, timing) that would unlock their potential here.
BEST	Shows how similar people executed that plan and got the results here.

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L3, Fit. What unlocks their potential HERE? It's a mix of alignment, role requirements and cultural fit. Good: understand their goals and believe they can achieve them here; understand the environment needed to unlock their potential and believe it exists here; understand cultural fit issues here. Better: able to create a plan (projects and timing) that would unlock their potential here. Best: able to show how a similar candidate's execution against that plan resulted in the desired performance here.

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Your problem is their opportunity.

FIRES FORGE PEOPLE

The hard team can be the growth role.

Show them the fire, eyes open. Wrong people run away; the right ones get excited.

BELIEVE IN THEM

Maybe no one ever did.

Explain why the job will be hard, and why **THEY** will succeed.

BE CONCRETE

Training starts in the interview.

Give feedback, show our onboarding process, discuss how they would solve **our problems.**

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Fit: your problem is their opportunity. Fires forge people: a team in trouble can be the best place to grow. Show them the fire with eyes open; the wrong people run away, the right ones get excited. Believe in them: maybe no one ever did. Explain why the job will be hard, and why THEY will succeed. Be concrete: training starts during the interview. Give feedback, show our onboarding process, and discuss how they would solve our problems.

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[CASE STUDY]

Joseph

[Sr. Dir of Engineering, MixPanel]

Tells the stories.

THE MOVE

Learns what motivates them.

THE PLAN

Shares how previous engineers succeeded.

STEAL THIS

Show them their future on **your** team.

(our on-boarding plans come from him...)

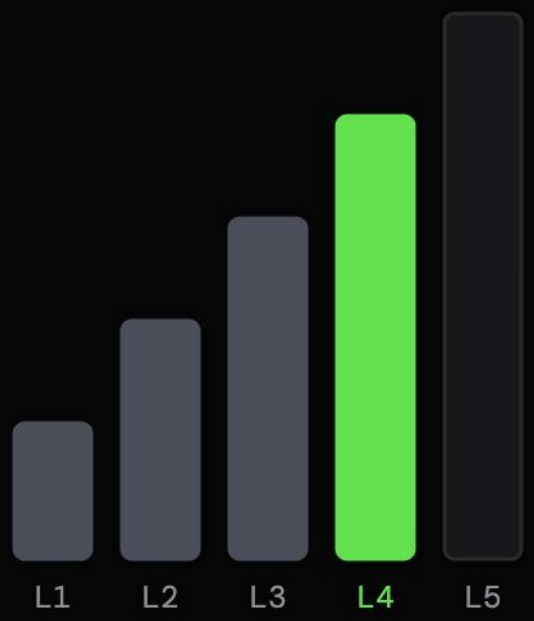


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[L4 · MAGNET]

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How do you attract talent?



Pro tip: you don't sell them.

GOOD	Shows agility and depth in areas the candidate values. Strength attracts strength.
BETTER	Impresses them: clearly better, without threat, where they want to grow.
BEST	Shows how you personally can grow them, in a way they value.

(No humble brags: be comfortable in your strengths and honest in your weaknesses.)

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L4, Magnet. How do you attract talent? Pro tip: you don't sell them. Good: able to demonstrate agility and depth in areas the candidate values (strength attracts strength). Better: able to impress the candidate: clearly better, in a non-threatening way, in key areas where the candidate wants to grow. Best: able to demonstrate how you personally can grow the candidate in a way the candidate values ("we can grow you"). No humble brags: be comfortable in your strengths and honest in your weaknesses.

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Strength attracts strength.

A PLAYERS	Want to work for leaders stronger than themselves.
B PLAYERS	Feel uncomfortable around A players.
C PLAYERS	Can't tell the difference between an A and a C.

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Strength attracts strength. Leaders want to work for leaders stronger than themselves. You know you have B players when they feel uncomfortable with A players. You know you have C players when they can't tell the difference between A and C players. Your interviewers ARE the pitch.

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[CASE STUDY]

John

[Staff Vision Engineer, Doxel]

Bring on the challenge.

THE MOVE

Discusses HIS unsolved, **hard** problems.

THE EFFECT

"I'll learn so much from John."

STEAL THIS

Interview on the real work, not hypotheticals.

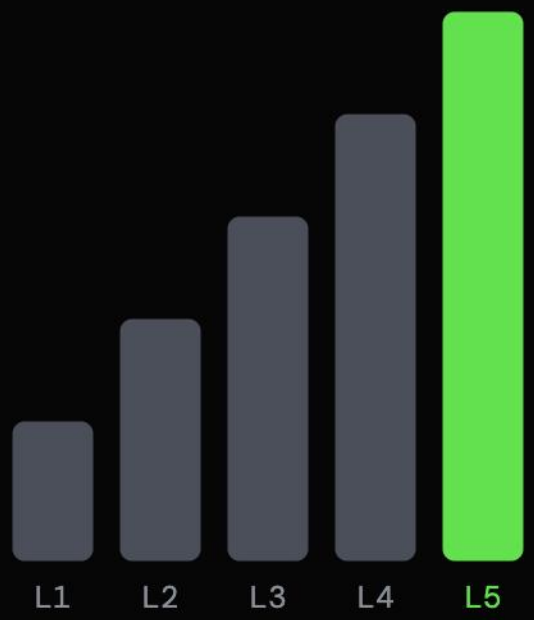


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Alex joined Doxel partly because of him.

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How do you land 10× talent?



If it's about the compensation, you've already lost.

GOOD	Connects with the candidate deeply, in a way that matters to them.
BETTER	Pitches the role, team and company with emotional impact.
BEST	Shows why they would win here vs. other options, and it resonates.

(We only live once & work is a LOT of hours — show them your AWESOME self)

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L5, Landing. How do you land 10x talent? If it's about the compensation, you've already lost. Good: able to deeply connect with the candidate in a way that is meaningful to them. Better: able to pitch the value of the role/team/org/company in a way that has emotional impact. Best: able to show them why they would win here vs. other options, and have it resonate. We only live once, and work is a LOT of hours: show them your AWESOME self.

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“I joined this company to work with you.”

When you start hearing this, you’re at L5.

People decide with emotion, then find the reasons. Emotion is high-order computation.

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When you start hearing "I joined this company to work with you", you are at L5. People ultimately make decisions for emotional reasons, and come up with the rational ones to back them up. That's not a bad thing: emotion is very high-order computation. So tap into it. Show them you understand what pulls on their heartstrings, and why, by joining us, this won't be a JOB.

[CASE STUDY]

Wade

[CTO, Amplitude]

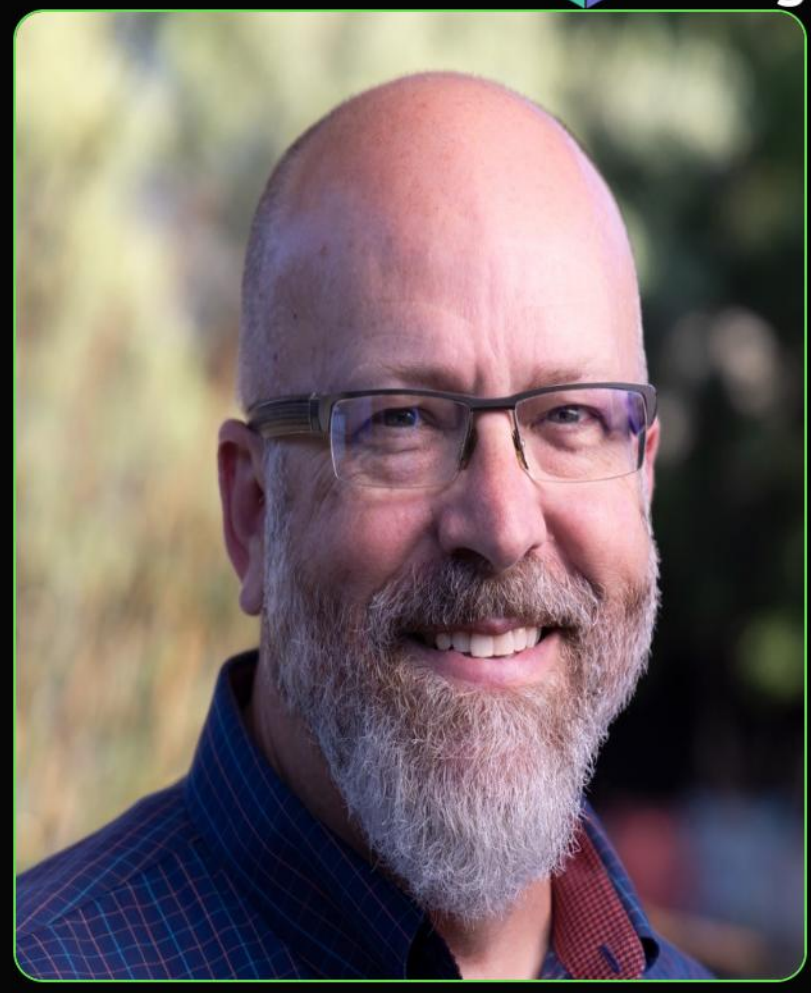
The Guru.

THE MOVE
Finds the emotional strings unique to you.

THE EFFECT
Plucks them. You can't ignore it.

STEAL THIS
Learn what moves them, then speak to it.

(Show them the path that lies ahead — and how you'll help them navigate it.)

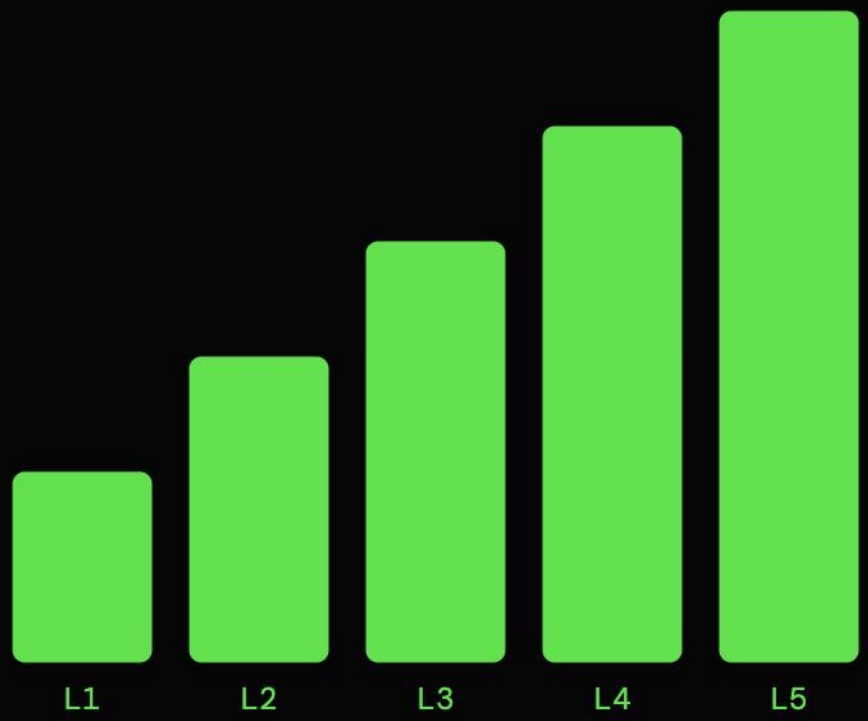


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Wade, the gold standard (for me). Quickly understands the emotional strings that are unique to you, and plucks them for a vibration that cannot be ignored.

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All five: an A-player interviewer.



L1 **Competence** · Do they meet our bar?

L2 **Potential** · How far can they grow?

L3 **Fit** · What unlocks them here?

L4 **Magnet** · Strength attracts strength.

L5 **Landing** · "I joined to work with you."

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Put together, the five levels make an A-player interviewer. Next: three rules that make every level work.

[RULE #1]

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Be interested.

RESPONSIBILITY

Connection
No distractions
(Turn off Slack and Claude!)

LOOK FOR

Motivation
Pride
Why they left

EMPLOY

Active listening
“Tell me more?”

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Rule #1: be interested. Take responsibility for being interested: create connection, leave distractions outside the room (turn off Slack and Claude!), lower barriers to effective communication, make the candidate want to expand on details. Look for: what motivates them, what demotivates them, excitement and interest points, fear and pain points, their level of technical, personal and social skill, what they are proud of, why they took a role, why they left it. Employ active listening and curiosity: "what?", "how?", "tell me more?"

[RULE #2]

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Be an advocate.

	GOOD FOR US	BAD FOR US
GOOD FOR THEM	**Great employee.**	They get fired when we figure it out.
BAD FOR THEM	They leave when they figure it out, or stay for the wrong reason.	Nobody wins.

Fit is established **jointly**.

FOR THEM

Is this the right next stage of their career? What do they want, and how will they prioritize?

DON'T GO NATIVE

You represent the company. Every candidate leaves an evangelist.

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Rule #2: be an advocate. Fit needs to be jointly established. Good for them and good for us: great employee. Good for us, bad for them: they leave when they figure it out, or stay for the wrong reason. Good for them, bad for us: they get fired when we figure it out. For them: is this a good place for the next stage of their career? What are they looking for? How will they prioritize? Do they have clarity on what they want and need? Within reason, help them figure out fit ("this could mean this or that, which did you mean?", "here is what I learned about you"). Don't set them up for failure. Don't go native: remember you represent the company. We always want candidates to leave as company evangelists. For us: is this an A player?

[RULE #3]

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Be someone they want to work with.

Park your ego | Be genuine | Be aware | Be a gracious host | Be excited | Be interested | Be wicked smart | Ask insightful questions | Ask hard questions | Be helpful

They're interviewing you, too.

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Rule #3: be someone they want to work with. Park your ego. Be genuine. Be aware. Be a gracious host. Be excited. Be interested. Be wicked smart. Ask insightful questions. Ask hard questions. Be helpful.

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Five levels, how to do each.

L1	**Competence**	Adapt to the candidate: standard questions, live problems, or their past work.
L2	**Potential**	Find repeated high-potential behavior, then probe for the blind spots.
L3	**Fit**	Lay out the plan, projects and timing, that unlocks them here.
L4	**Magnet**	Interview on the real work, and show how you'll grow them.
L5	**Landing**	Find what moves them, and show them the path ahead.

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Recap: the five levels, and how to do each. L1 Competence: Adapt to the candidate: standard questions, live problems, or their past work. L2 Potential: Find repeated high-potential behavior, then probe for the blind spots. L3 Fit: Lay out the plan, projects and timing, that unlocks them here. L4 Magnet: Interview on the real work, and show how you'll grow them. L5 Landing: Find what moves them, and show them the path ahead. Next, Arc 3: building the process.